As mentioned in his well-researched book, *Weapons of Peace*, Raj Chengappa once asked Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, 'You, more than anyone else, had the unique choice of building vehicles of peace at the space department or making weapons of war in defence. Why did you choose the latter when you know that it is capable of so much destruction and bloodshed?' Kalam answered: 'I had no qualms. By building such arsenal I actually ensure peace for my country. Now no nation dare attack us. These are truly weapons of peace.'[5] The world sat up to notice the emergence of India as a nuclear-weapon state.

The reaction of Pakistan was as expected. India's nuclear tests were described as 'reckless and highly provocative'. Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif stated in his address to the people, 'We will take all necessary measures to safeguard our security, sovereignty, territorial integrity and national interests.'[6] Gohar Ayub Khan, the then foreign minister, said, 'Indian actions, which pose an immediate and grave threat to Pakistan's security, will not go unanswered.'[7] Despite vigorous efforts and inducements, as also veiled threats by the US, Pakistan went ahead with its retaliation to India's tests by exploding five nuclear devices in the Chagai Hills on 28 May 1998, and a sixth two days later. These tests took place barely fifteen days after ours.

Pakistan has made it known that it would not be averse to the 'first use' of nuclear weapons in case its territorial integrity is threatened. It has blatantly indulged in nuclear sabre-rattling and blackmail both during the Kargil war and during the showdown in 2002 after the terrorist attack on the Indian Parliament. The same veiled threats emanated from Pakistan in October 2011 to deter another unilateral US military action inside Pakistan, after the strike that took out Osama Bin Laden in Abbotabad.

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[1] http://nuclearweaponarchive.org/India/IndiaArsenal.html

[2] http://www.indembassy.org.ua/english/news10.htm

[3] http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/India_and_weapons_of_mass destruction

[4] Ibid.